

Root cause analysis guide for feline aggression triggers and corresponding solutions — Action Checklist

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DETECT PAIN INDICATORS

- ☐ **Detect Pain:** Monitor your cat's grooming habits daily and watch for sudden increases or decreases in licking, as cats in pain often over-groom painful areas or stop grooming entirely due to movement discomfort.
- ☐ **Detect Pain:** Watch for postural guarding behaviors such as your cat sleeping curled tightly, flinching when touched on one side, or refusing to be picked up in ways they previously tolerated without complaint.
- ☐ **Detect Pain:** Track your cat's activity level changes including reluctance to jump onto surfaces they previously accessed, increased hiding behavior, or sudden withdrawal from play sessions that they once enjoyed.
- ☐ **Detect Pain:** Observe your cat's facial expressions for the characteristic pain face including slightly squinted eyes, ears held slightly back, and tension around the mouth, which indicates discomfort even when your cat appears outwardly calm.

TRACK ATTACK PATTERNS

- ☐ **Track Patterns:** Maintain a detailed incident log that records the date, time, location, circumstances preceding each attack, your cat's body language immediately before, and any environmental factors that may have contributed to the episode.
- ☐ **Track Patterns:** Document your cat's litter box habits and any correlation between elimination and aggressive episodes, since pain during urination or defecation can trigger redirected aggression toward nearby humans.
- ☐ **Track Patterns:** Review your incident log weekly to identify patterns in timing, locations, sounds, or specific activities that consistently precede aggressive behavior, which reveals the actual triggers your cat is responding to.
- ☐ **Track Patterns:** Establish a behavioral baseline by documenting your cat's normal temperament, vocalization patterns, and interaction style so you can recognize subtle shifts that indicate escalating stress or undetected pain.

IMPLEMENT SOLUTIONS

- ☐ **Implement Solutions:** Schedule a comprehensive veterinary examination to rule out medical conditions before assuming behavioral causes, as pain-driven aggression requires medical treatment rather than behavioral modification alone.
 - ☐ **Implement Solutions:** Create a safe recovery environment by providing hiding spots, vertical spaces, and quiet areas where your cat can retreat without being forced to interact when they are experiencing pain or stress.
 - ☐ **Implement Solutions:** Adjust your own behavior based on identified triggers by avoiding sudden movements near your cat, approaching them from their visual field rather than startling them from behind, and giving them space after painful activities like jumping down.
 - ☐ **Implement Solutions:** Consult a veterinary behaviorist when incidents persist despite environmental modifications, as cats with complex trauma histories or chronic pain conditions often require professional intervention beyond general guidance.
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